more difficult for honest citizens who found it impossible to use as there was no one willing to give change in lieu. The eminent economist Bibek Debroy, member of NITI Aayog, had to step in to defend the government, saying on television that this denomination was chosen since ATMs could only store limited notes.[2]

To add to the confusion, videos and messages began to circulate on social media, first stating that the new ₹2,000 notes had special security features such as an embedded nano GPS chip that would enable authorities to track and catch hoarders of black money. Then there were messages circulated on social media about a smartphone app that could ostensibly confirm if the new ₹2,000 bills were genuine or counterfeit. If you scanned them with your camera phone, and if the bills were real, a speech by the Prime Minister would start playing!

Other posts showed new notes with obvious printing defects and running colour. This led to fears that the new notes in circulation could be counterfeit.[3] In an attempt to provide clarity, the Economic Affairs Secretary, Shaktikanta Das, went on national television to state that the new notes had no additional security features, thus trying to dispel the rumours on the GPS nano chips and the 'triggered' Prime Minister's speech. This was followed by the ludicrous comment that if the colour did not run on a new ₹2,000 note, it was a sign that it could be fake.[4] Unfortunately, these announcements only added to the confusion.

The West Bengal Chief Minister and leader of Trinamool Congress, Mamata Banerjee, and the Delhi Chief Minister and leader of the AAP, Arvind Kejriwal, were the first opposition leaders to stringently criticize the move, citing the devastating effects it was having on the poorest citizens of the country.

In an effort to regain the confidence of the people, the Prime Minister made a highly emotive speech, in Hindi, on 13 November in Goa, asking people to grant him 50 days to restore normalcy.

Excerpts from his speech (*emphases* in this and all subsequent quotes have been added by me):[5]